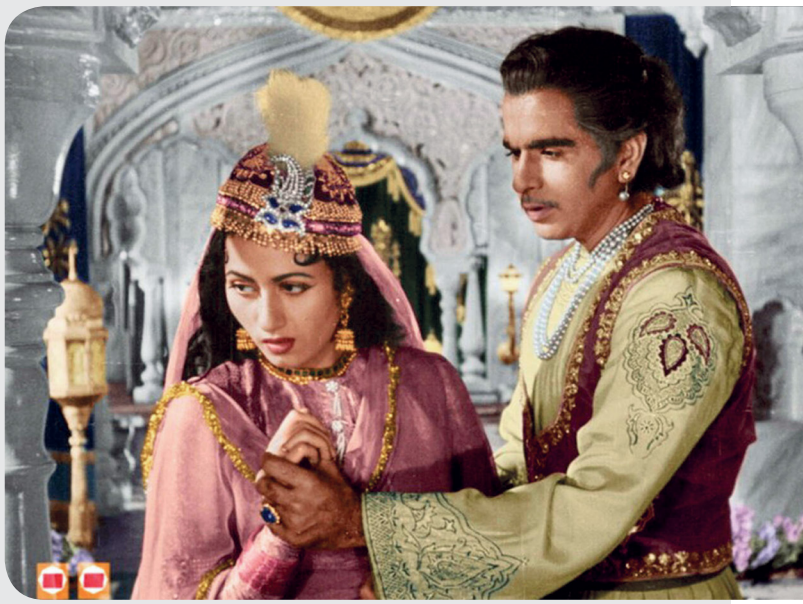
Mother India

(1957, Colour)

Some roles come once in a lifetime; so it was for the brilliant Nargis as Radha, the wife of a poor farmer. This Mehboob Khan epic is a towering landmark and is perhaps the best-known Hindi film title worldwide, telling a heartfelt story deeply rooted in the soil of India. The 12 songs work like chapters, each announcing a different phase in Radha's life of struggle. Mehboob Khan knew how to marry melodrama with a grand vision. *Mother India* was the first Indian film to be nominated for the Oscars in the Best Foreign Film category.





Mughal-E-Azam

(1960, B&W with three reels in colour)

K. Asif's dream took years in the making, but he never gave up and, in 1961, this visionary director released his impressive masterwork. Set during the 16th century in Emperor Akbar's reign, this is a purely fictionalised reworking of history, creating the now-legendary doomed lovers of cinema, Salim and Anarkali. Superior Urdu dialogue, spoken to perfection by exceptional actors of the ilk of Dilip Kumar, Madhubala and Prithviraj Kapoor, and Naushad's music made *Mughal-E-Azam* a game-changer in Indian cinema history. Many stage adaptations have been made of Hollywood films, but *Mughal-E-Azam* was the first Indian feature to be reworked for the theatre, most successfully by Feroz Khan.



Pyaasa

(1957, B&W)

Its intensity, sophisticated storytelling, subtle acting, Sahir Ludhianvi's poetry, S.D. Burman's haunting music, V.K. Murthy's lighting and framing that heightens the film's mood, adding psychological depth to the characters—all this and more have given *Pyaasa* a revered place in Indian film history. Besides its sharp observation of the dark side of human nature, the film tells a timeless story of an artist's disillusionment with a materialistic world—so far from the frivolous love story. In the hands of Guru Dutt, a true master of cinema, *Pyaasa* proves that Hindi film conventions have great power.

Photos: INDIA PICTURE